

HER WAY IN THE WORLD

tank iSPIRT to curate a sufficient number of fintechs for us to just show the innovations they were working on.” A large number of consultancies were also roped in for brainstorming sessions. The IT committee of SBI’s board was of great help. “It had people who truly understood the evolution of banking. Eventually, everyone rallied behind the idea.”

Bhattacharya’s former colleague Rajnish Kumar, who succeeded her as SBI chairman, nods in agreement. “An ability to build consensus and carry the team along, coupled with a pleasant personality, makes Arundhati a very capable leader,” he says.

With the backing of her team, Bhattacharya set her plans in motion. Her four-year term saw new initiatives such as mobile apps for retail, SME and corporate customers, roll-out of digital-only branches, adoption of AI and robotics to augment credit analysis and risk management, and paring of non-performing assets (NPA) through sales to asset reconstruction companies (ARCs). As for employees, they were given a wide choice of new training programmes and an appraisal system that sought to promote the best performers.

THE EARLY YEARS

Back in 1977, Bhattacharya had joined a very different SBI as a 22-year-old. The chairman and top management were distant from most employees. “We only knew the regional manager and his group, and once in a blue moon we got to meet the circle management, which is the state management,” she says. Management decisions would be communicated to employees through very large circulars. “Back in those days, we did read them. Today I don’t think people have the patience to do that,” she adds with a chuckle.

Her childhood years spent in the steel townships of Bokaro and

ARUNDHATI BHATTACHARYA (66)

AS SBI CHAIRMAN FROM OCT 2013-OCT 2017 SET 6 STRATEGIC GOALS FOR THE LENDER

- Digital
- Technology
- Improving service delivery
- Cost reduction
- NPA reduction
- Risk management

JOINED SBI IN 1977

Over the years, she worked across forex, treasury, retail operations, investment banking and human resources. Also did a stint at the bank’s New York office. Launched new notable initiatives like SBI General Insurance, SBI Custodial Services, SBI Pension Funds and the SBI Macquarie Infrastructure Fund

POSITIONED SBI AS A ‘BANKER TO DIGITAL INDIA’ BY PUSHING:

- Mobile apps for retail, SME and corporate customers
- Promoting digital-only branches, a first-of-its-kind initiative in India
- Adopting AI and robotics for enhanced credit analysis, risk management and services
 - Building out POS terminal business
 - Paring of bad loans through sales of NPAs to ARCs
- Launching new training programmes and appraisal methodology to promote meritocracy among employees

CURRENT ROLE

Joined as Chairperson and CEO of Salesforce India in March 2020

OTHER MILESTONES

Ever a strong votary of a less-cash economy, she emerged as the key spokesperson from the banking sector of the government’s 2016 demonetisation exercise

Published her autobiography, *Indomitable: A Working Woman’s Notes on Work, Life and Leadership*, in January 2022

FUTURE PLANS

Fulfilling her long-cherished dream of submitting a thesis on financial inclusion

MANTRA FOR GEN Z

“Practice giving back to society as that’s the best way of achieving personal satisfaction”

